

CAR RENTAL REQUEST AUTOMATION IN SERVICENOW

Phase 1: Ideation Phase

Defines the problem, the people affected, the options considered, and the idea chosen to solve it.

Item	Details
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Platform	ServiceNow (Service Catalog, Flow Designer, Business Rules)
Document	Phase 1 of 5

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1.1 Background and Context

Employees regularly need a car for business-related travel. In most organizations the request travels through informal channels such as email, chat messages, or a shared spreadsheet, and then passes by hand from the requester to a manager and on to whoever arranges the vehicle.

ServiceNow is an enterprise workflow platform whose **Service Catalog** is designed for exactly this kind of employee request: a form-driven order that becomes a tracked record and moves through approval and fulfilment. This project uses the Service Catalog together with **Flow Designer** to turn the informal car rental process into a structured, automated one.

1.2 Problem Statement

The current, manual process produces four recurring problems:

- **No standard intake.** Dates, locations, and car type arrive in different formats, so requests are often incomplete.
- **Manual approval chasing.** The manager has to be reminded, and there is no record of who approved what and when.
- **Poor visibility.** The requester cannot see whether the request is pending, approved, or assigned.
- **Manual hand-off.** Someone has to forward approved requests to the Transport team, and forwarded details can be lost or mistyped.

The current process, step by step

Step	What happens today	Pain point
1. Request	The employee emails or messages someone with trip details	Free-form text; details such as date or drop location are often missing
2. Clarification	The recipient replies with questions	Back-and-forth adds delay before anything can be approved
3. Approval	A manager agrees by email or verbally	No consistent record; easy to miss or forget
4. Hand-off	The request is forwarded to the Transport team	Manual step; details can be lost in the forward
5. Confirmation	Transport replies to the requester	The requester has no live status and must ask for updates

1.3 Root Cause Analysis

Symptom	Root cause	Consequence
Incomplete requests	No mandatory structure for the information	Delays while details are collected
Lost or forgotten approvals	Approval lives in email threads, not on the request	Unclear status; no audit trail
Transport learns late	Hand-off depends on a person remembering to forward	Missed or late arrangements
Requester keeps asking for status	No single record to look at	Extra effort for everyone

1.4 Business Objectives and Success Criteria

#	Objective
1	Provide a standardized Service Catalog item for car rental requests
2	Automate the approval workflow so requests reach an approver without manual follow-up
3	Automatically assign an approved request to the Transport team as a task
4	Notify the requester by email and raise an incident when a car turns out to be unavailable
5	Track every request in one centralized system for visibility and auditing
6	Improve the end-user experience with faster, transparent status updates

The project is successful when each of the following can be demonstrated:

Success criterion	How it is verified
Every request enters through one standard form	The catalog item is the only intake and shows all seven fields
Every request is uniquely traceable	Ordering generates a REQ number and a RITM number
No approval happens outside the system	The decision is recorded in the Approval field and the Approval history journal on the RITM
Approved requests reach Transport with no manual forwarding	A catalog task is created automatically and assigned to the Transport Team
The requester is informed	An email is sent to the address of the Requestor variable
Unavailable cars are escalated	The business rule inserts an incident referencing the request number

1.5 Stakeholder Analysis

Stakeholder	Role	Needs / Expectations	Impact of Automation
End Users (Requesters)	Employees requesting a car	Easy form, quick approval, visibility into status	Faster access, transparent tracking
Approvers	Approve or reject the request	Structured approval process, policy enforcement	Automated approval routing, better audit trail
Transport Team	Fulfil approved requests	Clear, complete request data, automatic task assignment	Standardized intake, fewer errors, less manual work
ServiceNow Admins	Configure catalog, flows, notifications	Flexible, scalable, maintainable solution	Easier maintenance, configurable workflows

Before and after, from each stakeholder's point of view

Stakeholder	Before automation	After automation
Requester	Writes a free-form message, then waits and asks for updates	Fills one form, gets a request number, and tracks the record
Approver	Finds the request in an email thread and replies	Receives an approval task tied to the request and decides in one place
Transport Team	Waits for a forwarded message with unclear details	Receives a catalog task assigned to the team with the request attached
Admin	Has no single place to see or change the process	Maintains one catalog item and one visual flow

1.6 Brainstorming and Idea Evaluation

Five ways of solving the problem were compared against the qualities the project needs.

Option	Structured intake	Automated approval	Audit trail	Build effort	Portable
A. Email or spreadsheet	No	No	No	Low	No
B. Incident form used for requests	Partial	Partial	Yes	Low	Yes
C. Service Catalog with manual follow-up	Yes	No	Partial	Low	Yes
D. Service Catalog + Flow Designer	Yes	Yes	Yes	Medium	Yes
E. Custom scoped application	Yes	Yes	Yes	High	Yes

Decision: Option D was chosen. It covers every quality the project needs at moderate effort, and it uses features that already exist on the platform. Option E would add effort without adding capability for this scope, and options A to C leave the approval and hand-off problems unsolved.

1.7 Proposed Solution and Scope

1. A **Service Catalog item** named "Car Rental Request" with a structured form.
2. A **Flow Designer flow** named "Car Rental Req", triggered when the catalog item is ordered.
3. An **approval step**, followed by a **conditional branch** and **Catalog Task creation** for the Transport team.
4. A **Send Email** action that notifies the requester.
5. A **Business Rule** that creates an incident when a car is unavailable.
6. An **Update Set** so the configuration can be moved between instances.

In scope	Out of scope (possible later work)
Catalog item and form	Booking with an external rental vendor
Approval, task creation, and email notification	Billing, cost centers, or payment
Incident creation for an unavailable car	Live car tracking or GPS
Tracking through REQ, RITM, and task records	A full car inventory and scheduling system
Packaging in an Update Set	Dashboards and reporting

1.8 Expected Outcomes and Benefits

- One consistent request form for every employee, so requests arrive complete.
- No manual forwarding: approval leads to a task, and the task leads to a notification.
- Full traceability of who requested, who approved, and which team was assigned.

- A reusable pattern that can be extended to other request types, such as the software installation request outlined in the project brief.

1.9 Ideation-Stage Assumptions and Risks

Item	Type	Note
A ServiceNow instance with admin access is available	Assumption	Needed to build the catalog item, flow, and business rule
Approvers and the Transport Team exist as users and a group	Assumption	Needed for approval and task assignment
Users will order through the catalog rather than by email	Assumption	Adoption depends on making the form quick to fill in
Scope grows beyond the brief	Risk	Keep to the scope table; list extras as future work